

Checklist:

Product Dysfunctions

1. Dysfunction Self-Assessment

Check any that apply.

- ☐ We focus more on **shipping features** than achieving customer or business outcomes.
- ☐ Success is judged mainly by **internal metrics** rather than customer value.
- ☐ Product decisions are made **without** enough **customer research**.
- ☐ We spend too much time **optimizing small details** instead of creating meaningful innovation.
- ☐ Our roadmap is **mostly a backlog** of requested features.
- ☐ Prioritization depends too heavily on **spreadsheets, ROI** models, or **theoretical** scoring.
- ☐ **Priorities change** too quickly, creating whiplash for the team.
- ☐ Engineering is **overbuilding** for future scenarios that may never happen.
- ☐ Product meetings become **negotiations** to keep every stakeholder happy.
- ☐ The founder, CEO, or senior leader frequently **overrides** product direction without a clear framework.

Score:

0 checked = strong product habits

1-2 checked = some warning signs

3-4 checked = meaningful product dysfunction

5+ checked = urgent product leadership problem

2. Product-Driven Company Checklist

- ☐ We know exactly which **customer segment** we are serving.

- ☐ We build for **a broader market**, not one customer at a time.
- ☐ We understand which **customer needs** our product should meet.
- ☐ We also understand which customer requests we should **intentionally ignore**.
- ☐ **Product** and **UX** are closest to the customer.
- ☐ **Customer-facing teams** regularly share insights with product.
- ☐ Product decisions guide the priorities of **sales, marketing, engineering, and support**.
- ☐ We are comfortable **saying “no”** to requests that do not serve the target market.
- ☐ Our product strategy is based on **customer outcomes**, not stakeholder politics.
- ☐ We **avoid custom work** unless it benefits many customers or advances the strategy.

3. Customer Feedback Checklist

For each major feedback item, ask:

- ☐ Is this feedback from our target market?
- ☐ Is this customer using the product for the purpose we designed it for?
- ☐ Would solving this help many customers, not just one?
- ☐ Would it improve retention, upsell, activation, or customer success?
- ☐ Does it support our long-term product vision?
- ☐ Is it worth the engineering and opportunity cost?
- ☐ Are we reacting to pressure, or making a strategic decision?

Decision guide:

- ☐ **Act** if it improves value for the target market.
- ☐ **Investigate** if it reveals a broader unmet need.
- ☐ **Defer** if it is useful but not aligned with current priorities.
- ☐ **Decline** if it only serves a one-off or off-market use case.

4. Vision-Led Product Management Checklist

Key Customer Outcome

- ☐ We have identified the main customer outcome we want to improve.
- ☐ We can measure whether customers are getting more value.
- ☐ The outcome matters to customers and supports business success.
- ☐ The team knows why this outcome matters.

Customer Journey Vision

- ☐ We have mapped the customer journey from discovery to long-term retention.
- ☐ We understand where customers struggle today.
- ☐ We know what the ideal future journey should look like.
- ☐ The vision explains value from the customer's perspective, not as a feature list.

Product Strategy

- ☐ We know the gap between today's product and the future vision.
- ☐ We have clear milestones toward the vision.
- ☐ Our roadmap connects directly to those milestones.
- ☐ We have defined what we will not do.
- ☐ Engineering, design, sales, marketing, and leadership understand the strategy.

5. Roadmap Health Checklist

- ☐ Every roadmap item links to a customer outcome.
- ☐ Every roadmap item supports the target market.
- ☐ We can explain why each item matters now.
- ☐ We have removed low-value stakeholder requests.
- ☐ We are not over-prioritizing the loudest customer or executive.
- ☐ We balance short-term needs with long-term product direction.
- ☐ We give initiatives enough time to succeed before pivoting.
- ☐ We review whether shipped work actually created customer value.

6. Leadership Alignment Checklist

- ☐ Leadership agrees on the target customer.
- ☐ Leadership agrees on the customer outcome we are pursuing.

- ☐ Leadership understands the trade-offs behind the roadmap.
- ☐ Product has authority to make prioritization decisions.
- ☐ Stakeholders understand why some requests are declined.
- ☐ The company has a shared product vision that inspires teams.
- ☐ Strategy is stable enough for teams to execute effectively.
- ☐ Product leadership communicates the vision repeatedly and clearly.

Final Action Checklist

- ☐ Identify which dysfunctions are present.
- ☐ Pick the top 1-2 dysfunctions causing the most harm.
- ☐ Define the target customer segment.
- ☐ Define the key customer outcome.
- ☐ Map the customer journey.
- ☐ Create a future-state product vision.
- ☐ Build a strategy with measurable milestones.
- ☐ Rework the roadmap around customer value.
- ☐ Say no to misaligned requests.
- ☐ Review progress regularly against outcomes, not output.